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The Highest Circle

The new club of the power elite, still dominated by moguls and mavens, is a celebration of India's creative brio as well

By S. Prasannarajan

It is as if only irony alone can bring some cheer to these bleak times. The most feted millionaire today in India and elsewhere is a slumdog. Maybe, as in the movie, only wit and perseverance can keep you on top of the game at a time when the lights are going out all over the highest shrines of capitalism. In the gathering darkness, desperate invocations have a socialist resonance. And suddenly, the cold breeze of mortality is wafting across the pinstriped republic of plutocrats, that sovereign state within the state that looked infallible till the other day. The unthinkable is upon us. The masters of the universe have feet of clay. Still, despite all the news of Apocalypse Tomorrow, let's not be fooled. The traditional relationship between wealth and power remains intact. The front row of the power elite—the Establishment—is reserved for people who know how to create wealth and play with it, no matter even if they are poorer by a few billions in the wake of the economic downturn. The sweep of their power, though, is not directly proportional to the size of their wealth; and that is why the richest is not necessarily the most powerful. Power is all about the ideas and attitude of the one who wields it. The business class that still dominates the Highest Circle tells more than a story of survival; it essays the boldness and ingenuity of a few who still make a difference to the lives of the rest—for better or worse. Today, in the age of bail-outs and stimulus plans, they may have realised the uses of governments but their power is not subordinate to the rulers of the day. That said, the INDIA TODAY Power List 2009 shows a shift in hierarchy, a shift that reflects an India where the money is matched by the mind. India is the stage on which some of the most exuberant shows on earth are mounted. India is the page on which some of the finest words are written. And we won't be surprised if *Jai Ho* becomes a global ring tone. Call it the reach of India's soft power. As the bad news from the free market multiplies, there is at least something to be happy about: the cultural capital is not melting down. And this list, though mostly populated by the usual suspects of moguls and mavens, is a celebration of India's creative brio as well. The classical architecture of the Establishment—built on the triangular structure of government, the military, and business—hardly exists in democracies. Usurpers and innovators continue to shatter its cosy equilibrium. The rustle of the following pages carries the power of the few whose privilege may be exclusive but not eternal.